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The country’s past isn’t strait-laced. Heritage walks are revealing this, from Delhi’s Sufi shrines that are symbols of queer love to Bengaluru’s Cubbon Park that has been central to the LGBTQIA+ community

ON INDIA’S RAINBOW TRAIL



K.S. Swati
swati.ks@thehindu.co.in

A few years ago, Nitika Arora, a storyteller and queer ally, hosted a *baithak* (gathering) in Delhi’s Mehrauli Archaeological Park to discuss LGBTQIA+ history in India. Midway through the event, she was taken aback when a woman in her 50s said, “Every time I look at queer people, I feel repulsed.” The strong emotion, however, also made the woman cognisant that she must face her prejudices. “I don’t know much about queer folks, and the few things I do know are mainstream stereotypes,” the Delhi resident explained. “I want to go beyond that and understand them.” Since then, Arora says she has felt a deep sense of purpose to help fight such stereotypes. Today, she leads a number of queer-focused walks and *baithaks* via Darwesh Heritage Walks, which she co-founded in 2013. She leans into history, literature, and art to bring the community’s layered past to the fore, through how they intertwine with the many monuments that

An actor from *Postcard from Colaba*, a multi-sensory performance piece and queer walk in South Mumbai. (YASH GUPTA)

pepper the cityscape. The Delhi resident may not have come back for another gathering, but Arora is hopeful that she has been able to help other visitors.

A layered history
Pre-colonial India was not strait-laced. The country has a complex, compelling narrative spanning centuries of gender fluidity and queer expression – from third gender representation in the *Vedas* and *Puranas* and same-sex desire in the *Kama Sutra*, to mythological references such as Shikhandi in the *Mahabharata* (born as a woman but assumed a male identity). During the Delhi Sultanate and Mughal periods, there are recorded acceptances of queer communities. For example, in the *Ain-i-Akbari* (a document detailing the administration under Emperor Akbar), “there are paintings of the Mughal court in session, with the *khwajasaras* [transgender and intersex individuals] on the side”, says Arora. There was even a subgenre of Urdu poetry, known as *Rekhti*, with references to homoerotic desires of women. “It [queer relationships] wasn’t frowned upon largely till the British came in,” she adds.

CONTINUED ON
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Annie Zaidi

How do people navigate a splintering of the self? This question is central to the plot of author and academic Tabish Khair's new novel, *Drown All the Refugees* (HarperCollins). While Khair's oeuvre often centres on global or transnational events, his fiction is often set in smaller towns. If *Jihadi Jane* (2016) and *How to Fight Islamic Terror from the Missionary Position* (2012) concerned themselves with the fused experiences of racism, indoctrination and Islamophobia in the Global West, *Namaste Trump* (2023) and *Night of Happiness* (2018) brought the conversation closer home to India. As with *Night of Happiness*, in his latest novel too, Khair's preoccupation with the unspeakable horrors unfolding around us takes the form of an encounter with the occult. This is, perhaps, inevitable as a rational mind searches for words to respond to suffering that feels, at first, to be beyond words. Edited excerpts from a conversation with the author:

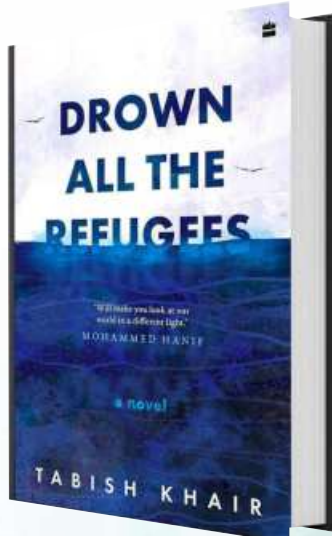
Question: *The title, Drown All the Refugees, is an obvious provocation, and the book itself is an answer to the provocation. What are your thoughts about the necessity for provocation in literature?*
Answer: I see everything that exists in literary tradition and practice as a tool. When you write a poem, for instance, you might use rhyme or avoid it – it depends on the effect you want to achieve. A book/novel's title is such a tool, too. It is an invitation to the reader, and as this is a novel that engages in a combative mode with current discourses of refuge, belonging, exclusion, isolation et cetera, I needed a title that would suggest this. Provocation, as you put it, was required. I think literature should not draw back from provocation if it enables a deeper incursion into realities.

Q: *As you write, it is possible to drown without leaving home. In the instance of Gaza, for example, one might drown (metaphorically, if not literally) not because you flee but because you refuse to. Knowing this, is refuge in law even possible?*
A: Somewhere in the novel, the narrator notes that the human right to flee to safety comes after another right that is increasingly overlooked in today's world: the human right to live safely wherever you already are. Gaza is the most blatant example of the world ignoring that basic right. And there are so many other examples: official estimates put refugees at 41 million today and the number of internally displaced people at 83 million at least. They are not even refugees: to claim to be a refugee, you need to cross a national border. So yes, refuge as it exists in international law,

IN CONVERSATION

GHOSTS OF GAZA

Author-academic Tabish Khair on his new novel, *Drown All the Refugees*, and why literature must provoke to remain truthful



is hardly possible for many actual refugees, and at least double that number is just as vulnerable and displaced without even qualifying for refugee status. That's where we are, alas.

Q: *Key to the plot of this novel is the fragmentation of people (separation of shadow and substance). Is restoration after fragmentation impossible, especially when it comes to cultures rather than individuals?*
A: You will recall that Raymond Williams noted that the word 'individual' comes from the same root as 'indivisible' and in the medieval period it suggested as much: the 'individual' was indivisible from society and both were joined against the strict mediaeval hierarchy. The individual needed her society and vice versa. All this changed with the dominance of capital. In the 19th century, many thinkers and writers noticed this: they warned how the 'money nexus' would not just separate neighbour from neighbour, but also step in between members of the same biological family. You can see this happening today but it does not happen in all families. Why? Because they have worked on creating other, personal, individual lines of connection –

talking, touching, acting together, giving and taking, understanding across differences. That is also what is suggested by the novel in its action and the bit of hope at the end – at least for the narrator and his newfound companions. I guess one needs to start small, but restoration remains a human possibility.

Q: *You use the phrase 'a sensible distance' at one point. How much distance is sensible, in the sense that such distance is an enabling rather than a disabling force?*
A: For me, sensible distance is required to live with difference. You do not want total identification. You do not want absolute sameness. One needs to live with difference. It is this that makes me, me, and you, you. This requires

sensible distance. I also use the expression to stress sense as in sensate, as in sensing, touching, feeling.

Q: *Your protagonist writes of people "who think they are living, but have long been dead... dead in the minds that matter". The novel is structured as a direct address to another writer from a language/culture that does 'matter'. If literature too is embedded in a system of hierarchical power, is it possible to reshape the minds that 'matter'?*
A: Literature, as a commodity, as something sold, bought and marketed, is embedded in a system of hierarchical power. True. But literature as what you read and what you write can be a different matter. I have argued elsewhere that literature is written with the awareness that language is essential and not sufficient. Language does not exhaust reality. It shapes our perception of reality, and is, in turn, shaped by reality. Hence, fixity or transparency is impossible in language. Literature does not just try to relate, communicate, using words clearly or effectively. It also employs gaps, silence, noise, contradiction et cetera. It is in these gaps, paradoxes and silences that it allows us space to question hierarchical power – as reader and writer. Not as commodity though.

The interviewer is a writer and filmmaker.



Singing in dark times

A thoughtful curation of stories and poems that shines a light on humanity

Sheila Kumar

Each piece in the anthology, *The View from Here: Stories and Poems of Many Indias*, serves as both a snapshot and a time capsule, capturing a distinct facet of India. Editors Githa Hariharan and K. Satchidanandan have drawn the selection from the respected literary journal *Guftugu*, bringing together works that deftly intertwine the personal and the political.

The collection explores themes of discrimination based on caste, religion and gender, with each writer and poet conveying these concerns in their unique voice and style.

Kamala Das' 'The Holy Cow', which opens the anthology, is written in her trenchant, fearless style and exposes the injustices perpetrated by religious figures. In contrast, Saadat Hasan Manto's allegorical tale of a monkey uprising ('The Revolt of Monkeys', translated by Muhammad Umar Memon) employs satire and black humour to incisive effect, holding a mirror to human folly.

Several stories also confront the enduring realities of caste discrimination. In Dalpat Chauhan's 'The Visiting Card', a young woman from a marginalised caste perseveres in her ambition to earn a doctorate despite the prejudice that threatens to derail her future. Yet, Chauhan suggests that such triumphs remain incomplete without an accompanying inner transformation: although she earns her Ph.D., she still hesitates to confront her former tormentor.

Like Chauhan's protagonist, the young Irula girl in Zai Whitaker's 'Roots' too attempts to alter the course of her life. So does Sridhar, the boy kept away from his father who is of a different caste, in Aparna Karthikeyan's story 'Sridhar's Father'. It is this emotional undercurrent – the quiet resilience of characters determined to challenge entrenched hierarchies – that gives these narratives their lasting impact.

Fighting polarisation

Other stories examine the many ways in which gender-based discrimination shapes women's lives. In Latha Viswanathan's 'Brittle', a young girl observes the circumscribed existence of an older woman. Salma's 'The Orbit of Confusion', written in an epistolary form, portrays women trapped in a cycle of inflicting hurt on one another. Its closing revelation prompts both the protagonist's daughter and the reader to reassess what has come before.

The most affecting among these stories is Bolwar Mahamed Kunhi's 'Iddath', a poignant portrait of a young widow and her hopes, dreams and

desires. It is a masterful exploration of unfulfilled sexual longing and the profound loneliness that accompanies it, with a lingering melancholy that underscores the emotional barrenness of her life.

Religious discrimination also emerges as a recurring concern. Asma Anjum Khan's delightful 'Of Beef, Biryani and Ghafoor' offers a heartening reminder that friendship between a Hindu and a Muslim can endure despite the polarisation of the times. In stark contrast, Vaasanthi's powerful 'Idaiveli-Gap' shows how the wrongful incarceration of a young Muslim man continues to imprison him long after his release, as invisible barriers confine him to a life he never chose. Gita Jayaraj's 'Kashmir Album',

meanwhile, is unsparing in its portrayal of life under siege in the Valley.

The decision to end this section with Jayant Kaikini's 'Unframed' holds out a ray of hope. Told in his characteristic observant, gentle and understated style, it celebrates the bonds that can form between strangers, ultimately affirming the triumph of humanity over polarisation.

Words of conviction

Politics runs through the poems as well, though in broader, more lyrical strokes. Kashmir is the subject of T.P. Sabitha's 'Stones', an unflinching portrayal of a troubled reality that

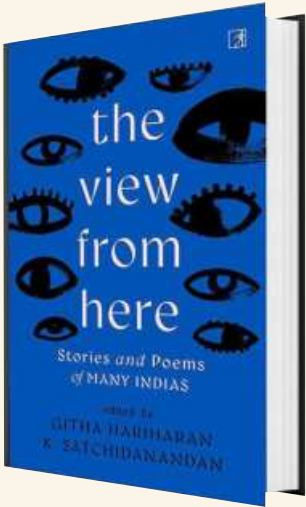
also serves as an elegy for a lost past. Manash Firaq Bhattacharjee's 'Time the Occupier: Two Poems' mourns both Kashmir and 16-year-old Hafiz Junaid, who was allegedly murdered in a hate crime. The lines are stark with underlying rage in 'On Eid ul Fitr': *They broke your body of fasting/ to feed wolves in the heart.*

Lal Singh Dil, meanwhile, conveys the pain of inter-caste love in just seven exquisitely crafted lines in the poem 'Caste'.

Elsewhere, luminous verses such as these dance on the page: *My songs are water, I am only a fleeting line on its surface* ('Two Ghazals' by Surjit Patar). Arundhati Subramaniam evokes longing in 'Let me be Adjective: Two Poems' with the lines: *But even as I meander/ let my trail/ be the thread/ that completes the circle/ I long to make around you.*

The editors quote Bertolt Brecht's famous reflection on singing in dark times, and this anthology answers that challenge with conviction. Its thoughtfully curated selection of stories and poems illuminates difficult realities while remaining consistently absorbing and deeply humane.

The reviewer is an author, journalist and manuscript editor based in Bengaluru.



The View from Here
Ed. Githa Hariharan and K. Satchidanandan
Simon & Schuster
₹599



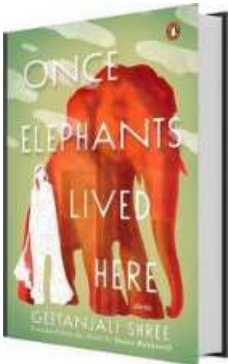
Author and academic
Tabish Khair

BROWSER

Once Elephants Lived Here

Geetanjali Shree, trs Daisy Rockwell
Penguin Hamish Hamilton
₹599

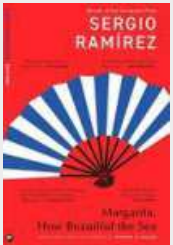
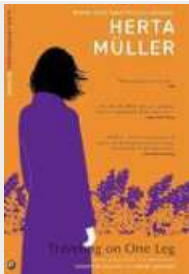
The 11 stories in this collection by the International Booker-winning duo defy convention in both their themes and narrative style. Written before *Tomb of Sand*, these stories trace the creative path that culminated in that magnum opus.



Egrets, While War

Tishani Doshi
HarperCollins India

₹499
Someone said, when children die, they become birds/ in heaven... Writer and dancer Doshi brings to life the violence and upheaval that mark our times through poems centred on birds. They become prayers and prophecies, omens and oracles, bearing witness to grief, loss and survival.



Aleph International Editions

To mark 15 years since its founding, Aleph Book Company has published three award-winning works of international fiction this month. As a part of Aleph International Editions series, five to eight acclaimed titles from around the world will be

newly marketed and distributed each year to reach a wider readership, says publisher Aienla Ozukum. The series opens with three distinguished titles: *Margalit and Rose* (2022), the only published work of fiction by American Nobel laureate poet Louise Glück; *Margarita, How Beautiful the Sea* (2008), Nicaraguan writer Sergio Ramirez's luminous reimagining of history, memory and nationhood; and *Travelling on One Leg* (1998), Romanian-German Nobel laureate Herta Müller's spare, unsettling meditation on exile, language and identity. Together, the three novels traverse continents and cultures while exploring the enduring human preoccupations of belonging, displacement and search for self.

Han Kang's lifetime of inquiry

The Nobel laureate brings together diaries, essays, poems, and her Stockholm lecture into a meditation on writing and violence



Han Kang is the recipient of the 2024 Nobel Prize in Literature. (AFP)

Mini Kapoor

At first glance, *Light and Thread* appears to be a convenient collection. There are diaries, essays, photographs, and poems clustered, providing physical heft to Han Kang's Nobel Lecture, delivered after she won the 2024 Prize for Literature. The lecture is remarkable. More remarkably, it has hooks for the rest of the anthology – there is, you realise, nothing disparate about this volume.

In 2024, the Swedish Academy, by design or inadvertently, acknowledged the new literary world unfolding over the past decade. Han Kang, then 54 years old, was a younger voice, a woman in a list that was slowly rectifying a gender balance, on merit, and the first Korean to be summoned to Stockholm for the literature honour. She had already announced herself globally with *The Vegetarian*, published in 2007 in the Korean, and, in English translation, awarded the International Booker Prize in 2016. The Nobel nudged readers towards her considerable body of work and the political-personal thread running through it.

Dwelling in questions

Han Kang carries us along on the questions that consume her in the writing of a novel. There are always questions to be answered, she says. And the asking of questions is how she has always been propelled as a writer. She opens her address by describing a little pamphlet she found recently in an old shoe box. She had made it by folding A5 papers and stapling them together. By hand, in pencil, the young Han Kang had drawn the cover illustration, titled it *A Book of Poems*, and written eight poems within. Eight-year-old Han Kang, it seems, set her older self up for a lifetime of inquiry. *Where is love?* she wrote. *It is inside my thump-thumping beating chest.* And: *What is love?/ It is the gold thread connecting between our hearts.*

The pattern had been set. “Each time I work on a novel, I endure the questions, I live inside them,” explains Han Kang. “When I reach the end of these questions – which is not the same as when I find answers to them – is when I reach the end of the writing process.”

In *The Vegetarian*, it meant asking what it means to reject violence. And to what extent can one evade being human – in this case by rebelling to try to become a plant? In *The White Book*, she asked if a living person could “lend” her life to someone

who died long ago, and too soon – in this case, her sister who did not survive beyond two hours of birth.

Lending life

Han Kang says that in her 20s, she would write at the beginning of every new diary: “Can the present help the past? Can the living save the dead?” In time, she realised she needed to flip the questions: “Can the past help the present? Can the dead save the living?” In *Human Acts*, about the brutal suppression of a pro-democracy movement in 1980 in Gwangju, her place of birth which her family had left for Seoul just a year earlier, she found the answers to the two flipped questions to be yes in some circumstances. “Of course,” she says, “I could not undo what had been done to the dead, to the bereaved, or to the survivors. All I could do was to lend them the



Light and Thread
Han Kang; trs Maya West, e. yaewon and Paige Aniyah Morris
Hamish Hamilton
₹799

sensations, emotions, and life pulsing through my own body.”

It is this physicality of lending life and nurturing that lies at the heart of her deeply moving garden diaries. In possession of a small north-facing courtyard garden, Han Kang learns to nurture it by “catching the sunlight shining south”, placing mirrors at angles that have to be adjusted every 15 minutes, and becoming ever more attuned to the Earth's rotation around the sun through the changing seasons.

Or, as she connects the two in a poem, *...I managed to live enough./ (Through writing.)/ Sunlight. I looked at the sunlight a long time.*

The reviewer is a Delhi-based journalist.



In this painting, an elephant named Sudhakar faces down the forces of Prince Aurangzeb; and (below) historian Munis D. Faruqui. (GETTY IMAGES)

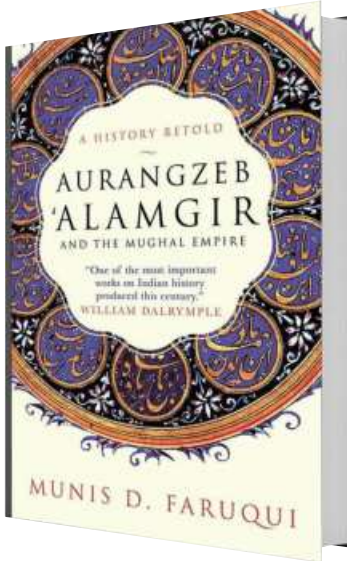
INTERVIEW

‘AURANGZEB NEVER FORCED NON-MUSLIM SUBJECTS TO CONVERT’

Historian Munis D. Faruqui says archival evidence points to a more complex emperor than popular memory and myths suggest

Manu S. Pillai

The Mughal emperor Aurangzeb died in 1707. But even in 2026, he remains a polarising figure in public imagination. Munis D. Faruqui's *Aurangzeb 'Alamgir and the Mughal Empire* (Juggernaut Books), however, offers a nuanced picture. Sparkling with fresh insights and fascinating new details, the book offers a richer, fuller picture of Aurangzeb. It also responds to the controversies around him. Excerpts from an email interview with Faruqui, a historian in the department of South and Southeast Asian Studies at the University of California, Berkeley:



Question: *Aurangzeb is generally perceived as a bigot. But you show how, in his own lifetime, his piety won the admiration of even his opponents. What was Aurangzeb's relationship with religion?*

Answer: Alamgir (his regnal name) was deeply religious. But the same was true for his brother and father. What differentiated Alamgir was his strong legalistic bent. As my book shows, he looked to Islam-inspired solutions to try and solve the empire's many political, social, and financial problems. He honestly believed they would work when other possibilities had failed. How could they not, given their origin in God's word?

At the same time, Alamgir was also pragmatic. Even if he believed Islam was the best religion, he never forced his non-Muslim subjects to convert. He understood that doing so would undermine the empire. Even if he thought that ceremonies like *jharoka darshan* [addressing the public at the balcony] ran up against his religious beliefs, it took him years to stop engaging in it. Indeed, he continued to encourage his heirs to undertake it because of its association with a Mughal imperial script. Even if he initially offered non-Muslim prisoners of war the choice of conversion to avoid a death

sentence, he eventually reversed it, realising that conversion did not assure political loyalty.

In sum, despite a fairly straightforward personal relationship to religion, his relationship to religion as emperor was more complex.

Q: *The earliest hagiographies, written after Aurangzeb's death are, you argue, the root of many later distortions. Tell us more.*

A: Alamgir was surrounded by competing factions when he died. One of them, sidelined by his successor Bahadur Shah I, started a memorialisation project, writing histories of Alamgir and collating his correspondence and administrative documents. The goal was to create an unfavourable comparison between Bahadur Shah I and his father. Essentially, they played up Alamgir's religiosity and credentials as a great Muslim ruler. The exercise was repeated against various successors whenever this group was on the political outs. However, what rendered the project so potent in the long run was its unfolding against a larger backdrop of rising non-Muslim political groups (Marathas, Jats, Sikhs), empowered economic groups

(Banias, Jains), and the general upward mobility of non-Muslims. Downwardly mobile Muslim communities, fearing the recession of their power, drew on this deeply misleading, communal well of historical writing around Alamgir to attempt to shore up their position. This historiographical strand became foundational to later Muslim nationalist visions. It also became an easy tool for anti-Muslim ideologues to highlight Mughal excesses.

Q: *One tension I find is that Aurangzeb's actions may be interpreted as imperial acts, but from the non-Muslim perspective, also remembered as religious persecution.*

A: Alamgir/the Mughals rarely (dare I say, never?) attacked groups out of religious malice alone. There always seems to have been an underlying political reason. How else can one explain the willingness of men like Durga Das Rathor or Chhatrasal Bundela to excoriate the emperor in religious terms when fighting him, but then tamp down that language when their political aspirations

were accommodated? Unfortunately, what gets selectively remembered are the religious fulminations.

I think the Sikh case offers an interesting twist though. What set them off against the Mughals was an emerging Sikh identity that twinned spiritual power with a rejection of Mughal political authority. Seen from the imperial perspective, what gave the Sikhs the right to reject longstanding Mughal authority? Nothing. As a result, the Mughals and their allies (Hindu and Muslim) used every play in the book, including persecutory tools, to crush the Sikhs. Ultimately, however, did Sikh-Mughal relations run aground because of religious impulses or the Sikh rejection of Mughal authority? I would say, the latter.

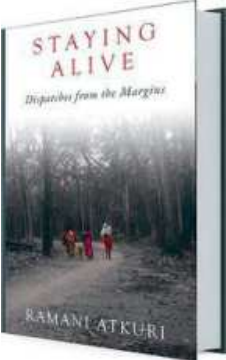
Q: *As a historian working in today's distinct circumstances, how do you personally engage with a complicated figure like Aurangzeb?*

A: I was repeatedly advised to work on any period other than this and anyone but Aurangzeb/Alamgir. Many feared that I was opening myself to personal disparagement at best and physical violence at worst. My response has been to try and tell the story in as dispassionate a way as I can, letting my archive guide me. If I had, for example, found lots of instances of forced conversion, I would have detailed them. The reality is that I did not. Does this mean that those instances are not out there? They might be. I will be the first to welcome them as long as the correctives are based in archival work and are attentive to the nature of the sources and the contexts in which they were produced. I can only hope that people will see my book as an opening, not the end, to an ongoing conversation.

The interviewer is a historian.

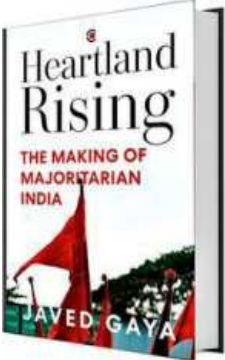
Staying Alive: Dispatches from the Margins

Ramani Atkuri
Pan Macmillan India
₹399
Atkuri examines the inequalities that shape healthcare access in underserved regions, using ground-level reporting and real-life stories to argue that quality healthcare should be a fundamental right.



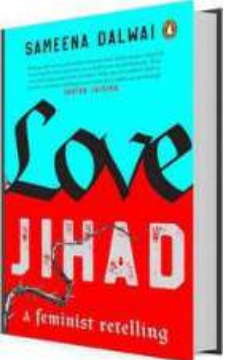
Heartland Rising: The Making of Majoritarian India

Javed Gaya
Westland Books
₹699
Gaya examines how the choices made during Partition and the framing of the Constitution shaped modern India. He traces the decisions that laid the groundwork for contemporary majoritarianism.



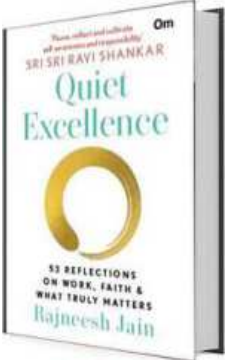
Love Jihad: A Feminist Retelling

Sameena Dalwai
Penguin Books
₹599
The book argues that the term 'love jihad' is a surveillance slogan used to police interfaith couples. It blends personal stories, humour, poetry, legal cases, and data to critique the politics surrounding love, faith, and state control in India.



Quiet Excellence

Rajneesh Jain
Om Books International
₹699
Jain shares 52 reflections he has drawn from decades of leadership, responsibility, and lived experience in this personal collection. The book is a guide and a companion for anyone striving to build not just a successful career, but a life of depth, balance, and purpose.



(Clockwise from below) Participants and performers at *Postcard from Colaba*; Nitika Arora of Darwesh Heritage Walks; and Bengaluru-based archivist Siddarth Shanthala Ganesh leading a walk in Cubbon Park. (VASH GUPTA, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



ON INDIA'S RAINBOW TRAIL

CONTINUED FROM PAGE 1

Delhi's fluidity
The national capital has plenty of examples of monuments with a queer past. The 16th-century Jamali Kamali mosque and tomb in Mehrauli is one of the best known. It is here that Arora usually begins her walk. Jamali was a revered Sufi saint and poet, while Kamali's true identity – a disciple, a brother, or a male lover – remains a historical mystery. Oral traditions claim they were in love, and were buried alongside each other. The site has since been embraced by the LGBTQIA+ community as a symbol of queer love and proof of historical representation. Among the other monuments included in the walk are the Hijron ka Khanqah, a spiritual retreat for the *hijra* community, and

Bagh-e-Nazir, a walled garden built in the 18th century by Roz Afsun Nazir, a powerful *khwajasara*. "I never knew about Hijron ka Khanqah. The walk showed me that even today such hidden places hold so much value," shares Meenakshi Gandotra, a Delhi-based gender equity and social inclusion practitioner. "So many things are forgotten or neglected, and sometimes just taking a walk reveals these stories. I now see Mehrauli as a place of queer history and Sufism rather than just a market."

Stories from Ahmedabad
Across India, there are plenty of examples of sites and monuments with queer history. Think Madhya Pradesh's Khajuraho and Odisha's Konark with their depictions of queer love. In Karnataka, the Virupaksha Shiva Temple in Hampi features carvings of

same-sex and bisexual couples on its walls. "These belong to a spiritual practice that asked visitors to leave their erotic desires behind before entering, but they are also evidence of alternative sexual practices in medieval India," says Siddarth Shanthala Ganesh, a Bengaluru-based archivist and curator. Another example is Madurai's Meenakshi Amman Temple with its gender-fluid deities. Now, people are making an

effort to showcase these stories. In 2022, tour guide Muhammad Ali Turner from Gujarat started his heritage walks under the Gandhinagar Queer Pride Foundation (GQPF) banner. He relied on old books and maps to help show people the history of the LGBTQIA+ community in the walled city. Among the many sites is Badshah no Hajiro or Kings' Mausoleum, which houses the tombs of three kings: Ahmed Shah I, Muhammad Shah II and

Ahmed Shah II. There are stories of Ahmed Shah II being referred to as *divesho*, someone who loved both men and women. It could also suggest a male confidant. "The story survives only in fragments," explains Chitan Gandhi, a local historian.

Bengaluru's safe haven
In many cities, the walks go beyond monuments and temples. "Bengaluru doesn't have monuments like Delhi

does. Here, queer history is personal and human-centred," says archivist-curator Ganesh, who organised the city's first queer walk, adding that the IT hub was once an integral part of the queer movement in South India. "A lot of queer people who ran away from home [from States such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala] would come to Bengaluru because not only did the city have a large *hijra* community, it also had organisations that had started working for queer rights in the 90s," they say.

Among the many sites rich with queer history, Cubbon Park plays a central role. "Many runaways [from the 50s and 60s to as recently as the 2000s] spent nights in the park, under the safety of the trees," they say. Which is why when Ganesh decided to start their Queer History Walk in 2022, they chose the park. The route started near the entrance, moved to Queen's Park, and then to Campbell Grove and on. "A public park long favoured for clandestine queer

encounters, Cubbon is also where, in the 1990s, queer activism began. In 1994, for instance, the city's first formal self-support group for queer folks, Good As You, started here," they say. Today, the walks have been suspended after the State government imposed access restrictions on Cubbon Park. So, Ganesh is recalibrating. This year, they are considering a bar walk, visiting queer-owned businesses, or a tour that spotlights queer activism and sites of protests.

Street performance in Mumbai
In the financial capital, heritage walks have got an unexpected makeover. *Postcard from Colaba* is an interactive, multi-sensory performance piece written and directed by theatre practitioner Vikram Phukan that doubles as a queer walk. "Colaba was an imperial district, so it has grand buildings and Art Deco structures. A few films such as *Sixth Happiness* [directed by



A queer day out

Those unfamiliar with the city's LGBTQIA+ pop culture often sign up for the 'A Queer Day Out with Lunch' tour organised by travel boutique No Footprints. "It was designed with queer playwright and activist Esthappen S.," says co-founder Harshvardhan Tanwar. "The idea was to start queer conversations from the lens of cruising, the idea of subverting class and caste through fashion, and the like." Interesting facts that came up during the tour include why the Mumbai local train's 'two by two' (second set of doors in the second carriage) is popular with gay men; how Irani cafes are deeply tied to the city's queer culture; and how Fashion Street near Churchgate, with its lack of gender binary clothing sections, is popular with the queer community to subvert traditional norms. The tour (approximately ₹6,000 per person) starts at Kyani & Co., an Irani bakery. "It has historically been a communal space where queer individuals safely gather. In fact, in the city's 'queer scene, the term 'bun maska' is a cheeky in-joke for physical intimacy," says Tanwar. "In South Bombay, the colonial-era buildings with their thick columns are popular with folks wanting to steal an intimate moment." The tour ends with a meal at Cafe Ideal, a popular after-march spot during Pride Month. "We also include several activities – be it pushing boundaries at Fashion Street [a straight-passing guest once challenged himself by buying a hot pink top], doing a drag workshop or making a zine (pictured) with a queer artist."

Waris Hussein, with a gay protagonist) and *Bombay Boys* [directed by Kaizad Gustad] have romanticised it," says Phukan, who researched historical records for the show. Started in 2023, the roughly 1-km route passes through landmarks of South Mumbai's once underground queer scene, such as Cooperage Bandstand Garden, Oval Maidan, Regal Cinema, and The

Walls near the Gateway of India. "During the early 2000s, heavy policing and fear of raids at gay parties led to restrictions on visible expressions of queerness, including drag," he says. This often resulted in self-policing within the community. To create safer spaces, some gatherings moved to yachts in the Arabian Sea, where people could express themselves



Erased history of the Nawabs

Lucknow has always been fluid, according to Anubhuti Krishna, writer and founder of the heritage walk Lucknow with Anubhuti. As part of its oral history, there are references to same-sex alliances among the aristocracy, and how the Nawabs were great patrons of music and dance – often considered effeminate by the British. "Since the city was almost entirely razed to the ground after the mutiny of 1857, most monuments that may have had a queer past were destroyed," she says. But all was not lost. At the Bara Imambara complex, poet Asaf-ud-Daula's Aina Khana, or Hall of Mirrors, is a good example. According to the 2024 book, *A Queer Reading of Nawabi Architecture and the Colonial Archive*, by architects Sonali Mithal and Arul Paul, Daula used to invite Europeans to view his collectibles. But once inside, he would stand such that he was reflected in every mirror – proudly displaying his appearance and his sexuality that he was shamed for. Bhaktkhande University of Music (built on the bones of Pari Khana, founded by Nawab Wajid Ali Shah) is another example. The ruler often stopped official duties to convert his court into a stage where he performed Kathak. "A lot of people thought that made him effeminate, or interpreted it as evidence of queerness," says Krishna.



more freely. (This is part of the performance at Apollo Bunder.) The show relies on live poetry, monologues performed in verse, and audio files accessed on messaging apps.

Challenging prejudice
As the walks reveal, queerness in India has had a synthetic past. Writer and historian Ruth Vanita cautions against imposing contemporary identities on that. "The word 'queer' as it is used today means non-normative and marginalised. But most of the figures these walks discuss were not marginalised," she says. "They were highly normative and admired

figures. Nizamuddin Auliya and Amir Khusrro and other Sufis are examples. They were not practising some new 'queer' behaviour. They were teacher and student who openly displayed love that was celebrated in the Sufi context." History should also not be given a colonial whitewashing. "There is a widespread notion that queerbobbia was something introduced by colonial rule," says Eric Chopra, writer-political spokesperson Anish Gawande. "But we've always had fractures along caste and gender lines. It is not accurate to suggest that the boundaries of caste did not carry on to queerness. It is

important to acknowledge that queerness has always had to fight for its existence." What historians and heritage experts agree upon, however, is how revisiting these stories can challenge contemporary prejudice. "I truly believe that the arts are the biggest way we can remove ignorance. When you conduct a heritage walk, show a painting or bring out a film, change becomes possible," says Eric Chopra, writer, podcaster, and founder of the Indian history-focused platform, lithasology. Ultimately, these walks are not about identifying monuments with queer histories. They are about asking



We can make these spaces safer by reversing the unjust amendments to the Transgender Persons (Protection of Rights) Act. We can make these spaces safer by introducing a comprehensive anti-discrimination law that allows queer people to live and breathe freely, and visit these monuments without fear

ANISH GAWANDE
Writer and political spokesperson

whose stories are remembered and whose are erased, which is relevant today when intolerance is on the rise. "History is never simply right or wrong, nor does it end with a single interpretation. But today, the nuance and ethics of scholarship are being lost," adds Chopra. "We are becoming more intolerant, less critical, and perhaps less curious. So, the job of a historian and heritage storytellers is to interpret history." And not let the country forget any of its protagonists.

– With inputs from Surya Praphulla Kumar

GREEN HUMOUR

Rohan Chakravarty

A QUICK SIX-STEP GUIDE FOR EUROPE TO BEAT THE HEATWAVE



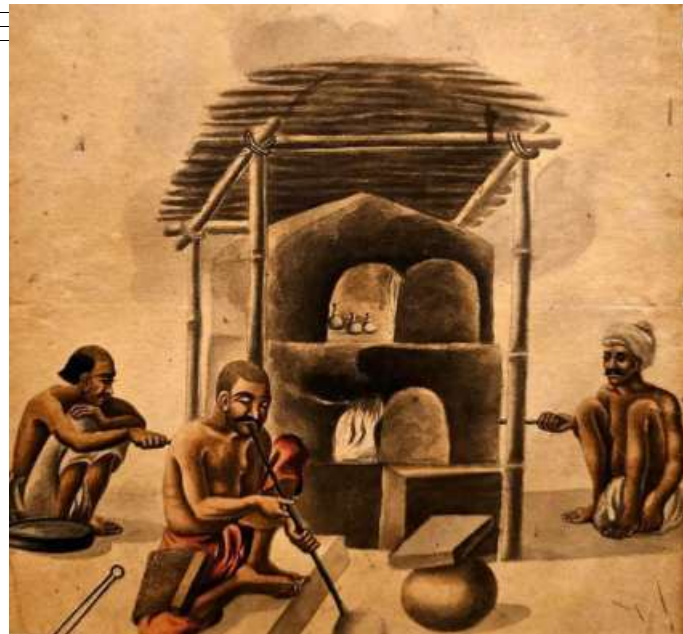
Kavita Kanan Chandra

Picture watercolours on imported paper, in delicate brushwork on pale, bare backgrounds, and the stark image of two men in *dhotis* working in a distillery. Or a woman, in blue-and-yellow *ghaghra-dupatta*, dancing in a palace hall as musicians play. These artworks belong to the 18th-century Indian painting tradition of Patna Kalam. This pre-photographic visual documentation captured the daily lives of ordinary people – vegetable sellers, blacksmiths and servants fetching groceries, among others.

Last December, Patna Kalam paintings were part of an exhibition at the Bihar Museum Biennale 2025, where it witnessed a renewed interest. Which begs the question: why is an art built to capture daily life now surviving only behind glass?

Hidden away in storage in art colleges, or confined to private collections, including the archives of the British Museum and the Victoria & Albert (V&A) Museum, London, the nearly lost Patna Kalam was reintroduced to the *Patna Kalam: Ek Virasat* exhibition held at Patna Museum between December and February, and to a workshop for keen students. Apart from the Patna Museum paintings, the exhibition featured works lent by Sanjay Kumar, a Dhanbad resident and descendant of the famous Patna Kalam painter Hulas Lal.

The regional art style "employed the technique of the Company School of Painting, with distinct characteristics intrinsic to Patna city – its people, culture and day-to-day life," says INTACH's (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage) Patna chapter convener Bhairav Lal Das. In it, Mughal miniature detail blended with European



BIHAR'S EVERYDAY CANVAS, REVIVED

Patna Kalam, an 18th-century fusion of Mughal miniature and European realism, is drawing students and hobbyists today

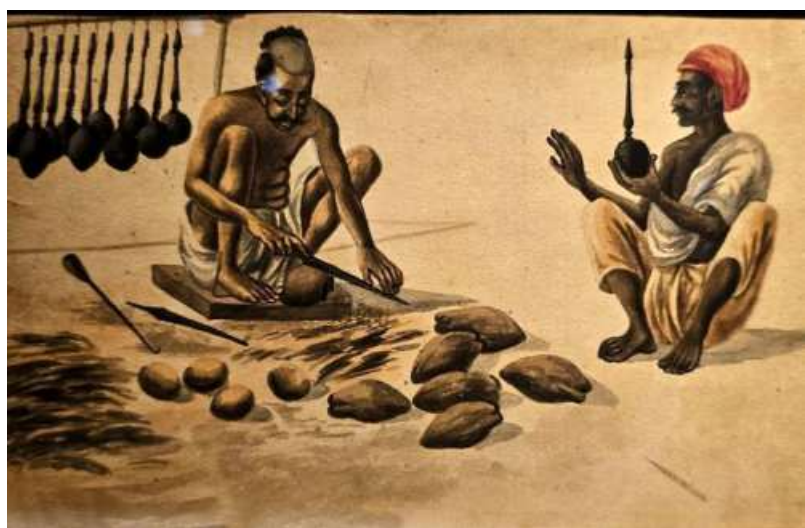
connoisseur Dewan Bahadur Radha Krishna Jalan, opened Planet Patna, a private museum with a large collection of Company Paintings, including Patna Kalam.

"My great-grandfather was passionate about objects of historical significance; he even purchased Napoleon's bed on a trip to Europe in 1935," says Aditya, adding that his father, Bal Manohar, exchanged colonial-era stamps for the Patna Kalam paintings. The museum at another site is open to all – with an entry fee of ₹100 – unlike the locked museum at his home, which is one of Patna's iconic landmarks for art lovers, the century-old

Quila house, better known as the Jalan House.

State of the art
Unlike the 800-year-old brightly hued Tikuli paintings, also of Patna origin, that were revived in the mid-20th century, Patna Kalam was lost after Independence. Tikuli, seen in home décor, gets its name from the *tikuli/binds* that women wear. "Patna Kalam has the influence of Mughal art, Rajasthani miniature painting and European style, while Tikuli art is influenced by Patna Kalam, Rajasthani miniature painting and Mithila painting," says Padma Shri-awardee Tikuli artist Ashok Kumar Biswas.

Sporadically, people have attempted to document Patna Kalam. Padma Shri awardee Shyam Sharma, former



(Clockwise from left) Patna Kalam artworks at Bihar Museum; INTACH workshop participant Anurag Kumar Verma; INTACH workshop participant Kajal Ojha's painting; a gouache on mica painting at Planet Patna; (bottom, left) Patna Kalam design on fabric by Sunita Prakash. (SUMIT SAURABH, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



We have plans to dedicate a permanent gallery to exhibit Patna Kalam paintings. Just as we took Sita's exhibition, Vaidehi Sita, in 2024, to several Indian states and abroad, we may do something similar for Patna Kalam

ASHOK KUMAR SINHA
Deputy director, Bihar Museum

principal of Patna's College of Arts and Crafts, has authored the book *Patna Kalam* (2011, Lalit Kala Academy). Sanjay Kumar, who comes from an illustrious line of Patna Kalam artists, says, "My grandfather Shyam Bihari Lal pursued Patna Kalam paintings till the end." Several paintings of his ancestral family are at the Metropolitan in New York, and in London's

Contemporary hope?
Bihar Museum deputy director Ashok Kumar Sinha hails Patna Kalam as Bihar's heritage. "We have plans to dedicate a permanent gallery to exhibit Patna Kalam paintings," he says. "Just as we took Sita's exhibition, *Vaidehi Sita*, in 2024, to several Indian

V&A Museum, and at the Patna Museum.

Prasad Verma, and museums like Jalan House," says Mohan, who observed in the workshops that the "fresh artists" (young students) performed better than, say, the Madhubani folk artists, in drawing human figures with the right measurement and colour scheme required for Patna Kalam.

INTACH has organised 11 Patna Kalam workshops since 2023, across venues. Participant and student Anurag Kumar Verma discovered the style there and it kindled his interest in studying art. He has recently joined the Faculty of Fine Arts, Maharaja Sayajirao University, Baroda. Patna-based arts and culture enthusiast Rachana Priyadarshini of Your Heritage start-up and a co-organiser for INTACH workshops, says, "From copying to incorporating contemporary elements, to drawing freehand, and observing architecture and people, we are on the right path."

Aditya Kumar Singh, an architect and part of the Urban Sketchers global artists community in Patna, says that sketching a contemporary building takes him half-an-hour while a Patna Kalam painting takes three days to make with full dedication. While Singh is doubtful about its sustenance, Lal Das says INTACH will provide incentives to budding artists, and help promote and sell their artworks too. Meanwhile, block-printing textile designer Sunita Prakash, through her company Bandhani, has trained women to paint traditional arts, including Patna Kalam, on fabric, and held exhibitions where these pieces have been sold too.

The writer searches for positive stories across the country.



Scan the QR code to watch the story of Patna Kalam's revival on magazine.thehindu.com

Comedy thriller *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* begins with a neat inversion of noir conventions. We meet fact-checker Paula Saunders (Tatiana Maslany), a divorcee, smack in the middle of a contentious custody battle, cursed with an unfortunate tendency to make bad situations worse.

The most unexpected detective on television today isn't a hacker or a cop. It's a fact-checker. Throughout her ordeal, Paula notices minute details that unravel a criminal conspiracy. In an era of AI-generated misinformation, it's her scrupulous fact-checking that drives the investigation. Sherlockian flourishes simply won't get it done.

Paula is amusing herself with the services of sweet, affable 'cam boy' – a man who sells racy photos or videos of himself – Trevor (who has his own OnlyFans-like website and the show). When suddenly Trevor (Brandon Flynn) is assaulted and kidnapped on camera, Paula starts receiving extortion messages. This is a gender-flipped take on classic noir: a down-on-his-luck, middle-aged protagonist drawn into a seedy world of crime and violence through an alluring female stripper. The twist works beautifully, making *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* (airing on Apple TV+) a genuinely chic, genre-bending show. Here's a thriller that is funnier than it needs to be and is an out-and-out comedy that's much more thrilling than you'd expect.

Everybody needs therapy
One of the big reasons why *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* is so entertaining is quite simple, really – this show understands loneliness at a molecular level. It is a beautiful, funny-sad portrayal of the silos we have created for ourselves in the smartphone era. Almost every character on display is deeply, desperately lonely, even if always surrounded by people.

Paula, her ex-husband Karl (Jake Johnson), detectives Baxter and Gonzalez (investigating Paula's case), and even poor Trevor, all look and sound like they are in dire need of a



BINGE WATCH

Move over, Sherlock

Noir comedy series *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* has the most unlikely detective – a fact-checker

therapy session or three. When we first meet Paula, she is pouring her heart out to Trevor while both are in various stages of undress on camera. I suppose recalling childhood trauma in your underwear is the 2026 version of a good weep on the therapist's couch. Another fantastic Apple TV+ series, *Margo's Got Money Troubles*, whose protagonist is an OnlyFans model, explores similar emotional terrain. It has been suggested by some reviewers that Paula's vocation – she is a professional fact-checker for a newspaper called *The Margin* – is a little on the nose considering the show's plot. I disagree. I think Paula's job is a careful choice on the part of the writers. Professional fact-checkers like Paula are now a dying breed. It's a very old journalistic craft that is on the verge of extinction. By contrast, Trevor's job (as an OnlyFans creator) is so new, it's virtually embryonic. They are on opposite ends of the temporal

spectrum, and this juxtaposition underscores the head-spinning pace of change in the world around us, one that Paula struggles to navigate. In fact, both *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* and *Margo's Got Money Troubles* capture the increasingly atomised nature of life in 2026 – the phenomenon called "main character syndrome" on social media. Nobody's got a job anymore, everybody is a corporation of one, hustling with a 'side gig'. Under this ideological framework, every moment of your life you have aggressively monetised is a mistake – hence the rise of platforms like OnlyFans. It is hardly surprising that the language of global finance spills into interpersonal relationships – you no longer simply meet people, you "invest" in them.

Apple's house style
These two shows, especially *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed*,



Aditya Mani Jha is working on his first book of non-fiction.

are representative of what has quickly developed into a bit of a 'house style' for Apple TV+ Originals. One of the major elements of this style is visual sharpness and detail-oriented design (after all, Apple is as much a design firm as a tech company). The result is symmetrical framing and a well-defined aesthetic for each show. The polished cinematography, desaturated colour palettes, and cleaner motion in chase sequences are prominent because of Apple TV+'s higher streaming bitrate (25-40 MBPS compared to 10-20 MBPS of other streamers).

But there are other commonalities as well – Apple TV+ shows tend to be high-concept narratives that are not readily summed up in a line or two. They often draw from literary source material (Isaac Asimov, Edith Wharton, Emily Dickinson, Paul Theroux et al).

Apple TV+ has also played a key role in bringing back the mid-budget genre show, especially mid-budget thrillers (Cape Fear, The Last Thing He Told Me) and comedies (*Mythic Quest*, *Platonic*). I say "bringing back" because mainstream Hollywood has slowly pushed these mid-budget films out of circulation, so as to focus on "event cinema" or "tent-pole cinema" (high-budget, multi-starrer crowd-pleasers designed to big screen releases). Apple TV+ not already linked to a longstanding, crowd-pulling IP has a slim chance of receiving a theatrical release these days.

In this era where 'bingeable' material is treasured over all else, *Maximum Pleasure Guaranteed* is a series that rewards considered weekly viewing without sacrificing the plot momentum it establishes early on. With every episode's deeply satisfying twists and turns, you discover something new about these inimitable characters – the noir plot as character development, something that is easier said than done.

Bengaluru's pavements are a CrossFit course of broken tiles, construction debris and garbage – and Arun Pai, 57, won't stop walking until he has cleared these obstructions. His video tutorial on dismantling sofas abandoned on the street got him a mention on Prime Minister Narendra Modi's *Mann Ki Baat* podcast. Recently, Pai, founder of the popular Bangalore Walks and the city's self-appointed 'footpath mayor', felt like the universe was finally listening.

Last month, after the Supreme Court declared that walking on footpaths is a fundamental right, Karnataka appointed a Bengaluru Development Minister, Krishna Byre Gowda, who promptly unlocked ₹70 crore to fix 2,000 km of footpaths. Pai, an until recently low-key man who has partnered with the government to improve walkability for two years, felt a burst of optimism, though it must be said that ousted street vendors are staging citywide protests in response to the 'Safe Footpath' campaign. It was in 2005 that Pai decided to quit his corporate job and dive full-time into conducting walking tours of Bengaluru, just as the city was morphing from a sleepy paradise into a startup magnet. He has spent the last two decades following the mantra of *kaam chaalu, mooh bandh* (keep working, keep quiet). The more Pai walked, the more he saw how Bengaluru could potentially be like any clean, walkable European city. He decided to combine civic action with storytelling.

Filling the gaps
While receiving an award from his alma mater IIM Bangalore recently, Pai revealed that he was one of the early volunteers of the viral civic



PERSON OF INTEREST

ARUN PAI: PAVEMENT DREAMS

The 'footpath mayor' of Bengaluru combines civic action with storytelling and long walks

movement, The Ugly Indian, which began in 2009 as an attempt to clean the city. "Cornell University theorised that it is successful because it does not define itself in opposition to anything else. It is about solving a problem," Pai says, adding that the success was also attributed to its central philosophy of "I will own it, I will solve it, I will not blame anyone". For Pai and other volunteers, The Ugly Indian was an idea by an anonymous group that believed, as he says, that "the doer is not important". Four years later, he formalised it with the India Rising Trust that now employs around 25 people, most of them blue collar workers. "We are like a contractor," he says. "We fill the gaps in government capacity." North Bengaluru recently partnered with them to clean up 100 chronic garbage 'black spots'. At some point, Pai realised that while Indians applaud the social work

Since 2005, Arun Pai has been conducting walking tours of Bengaluru via his outfit, Bangalore Walks. (ALLEN EGENUSE J.)

that happens in schools and hospitals, they don't think the same way about clean ups. "If I'm cleaning your street, you suddenly say, 'no, that's the government's job'. The urban middle class has a very curious attitude towards maintenance and cleaning, and it comes from our feudal caste background," he says. "But what people really care about is that when I walk or drive, everything should be perfect." That's when he pivoted from talking about cleanliness to discussing walkability. (When he spoke masked at The Ugly Indian's TED Talk 11 years ago, the title was 'Why Is India So Filthy?') Good footpaths, it turned out, was a more universal civic problem. It was at a mobility seminar in 2024 that Pai spoke as a representative of walkers and declared himself the footpath mayor of Bengaluru. "As is my style, I didn't want to talk unless I've done something," he says. So beforehand, Pai ran 100 km on the city's footpaths, rating all of them from 1 to 5. A top official in the audience instantly asked for and acted on his blueprint.

Catalysing urban change
In Pai's world, ward officers and engineers come on walks, Bengaluru's civic body chief is incredibly responsive, and officials join enthusiastically in creative endeavours, such as the recent IPL (Indian Pedestrian League) in which RCB (Raste Clean-up Bengaluru)

emerged a winner. "It's a middle-class thing to say everything is bad," says Pai, whose interactions with local officials are invariably friendly, rather than confrontational. "Solving walkability is a silver bullet for many civic challenges," he says. Fixing footpaths, he believes, can impact everything from a company's carbon footprint to the safety of women and pedestrians. "I'm getting a place at every mobility discussion because nobody else is standing up for walkers," he adds. One of the consistent donors to Pai's Trust is Rohini Nilekani, whom he refers to as "India's most generous woman". They met only in the third year after she began donating and their relationship was cemented over a clean-up. "I don't like to do meetings," he told her. "Shall we clean up the area outside your office?" Pai has his own blueprint on how you can catalyse urban change. Focus only on solving the problem; work within your means and don't ask anyone for money; don't take credit for it, in fact barter credit for access; be anonymous; attack a problem that everyone wants solved; involve all stakeholders whether you like them or not; do government work at no cost; give it time; let the action do the talking. "If you want to solve a problem at scale in India, use the compounding effect of media to inspire people and make them copy you," he says. "We are very good at emulating."

Priya Ramani is a Bengaluru-based journalist and the co-founder of India Love Project on Instagram.



GOREN BRIDGE The exuberance of youth Both vulnerable. South deals

Bob Jones
Today's deal is from a youth competition in Europe. South was Marius Austad, from Norway. His jump to six diamonds, with no club control, was a big gamble. He was bluffing that he did have a club control. Even if West led a club, he might shift to a spade at trick two. Given Austad's strong spades, there would

probably be nothing in dummy that would inhibit a spade shift. North raised to seven, reasoning that if partner could jump to six missing two aces, she could bid one more. Whew! Austad won the opening club lead with dummy's ace and cashed the ace of hearts to discard his remaining club. The trumps were likely to be breaking poorly after the pre-empt, so Austad led the 10 of diamonds at trick two and ran it. So far, so

good. He could draw the trumps now, but he would then need a 3-3 spade split. He reasoned that if the spades were 3-3, it would be safe to cash the high ones now. An opponent who was short in spades might also be out of trumps. That is exactly what happened, so Austad was able to safely ruff his last spade with dummy's remaining trump. He ruffed a heart back to his hand, drew trumps, and claimed. An exciting deal!

NORTH
♠ 6 5 4
♥ A Q 10 6 3
♦ 10 2
♣ A 3 2
WEST
♠ J
♥ J 8 5 4
♦ 6
♣ K Q J 10 8 6 4
EAST
♠ 10 9 7 3 2
♥ K 9 7 2
♦ Q 5 4
♣ 5
SOUTH
♠ A K Q 8
♥ Void
♦ A K J 9 8 7 3
♣ 9 7

The bidding:
SOUTH 2♣
WEST 4♣
NORTH 4♥
EAST Pass
Pass
All pass

Opening lead: King of ♣

QUIZ Easy like Sunday morning

All about pack and parcel

Berty Ashley

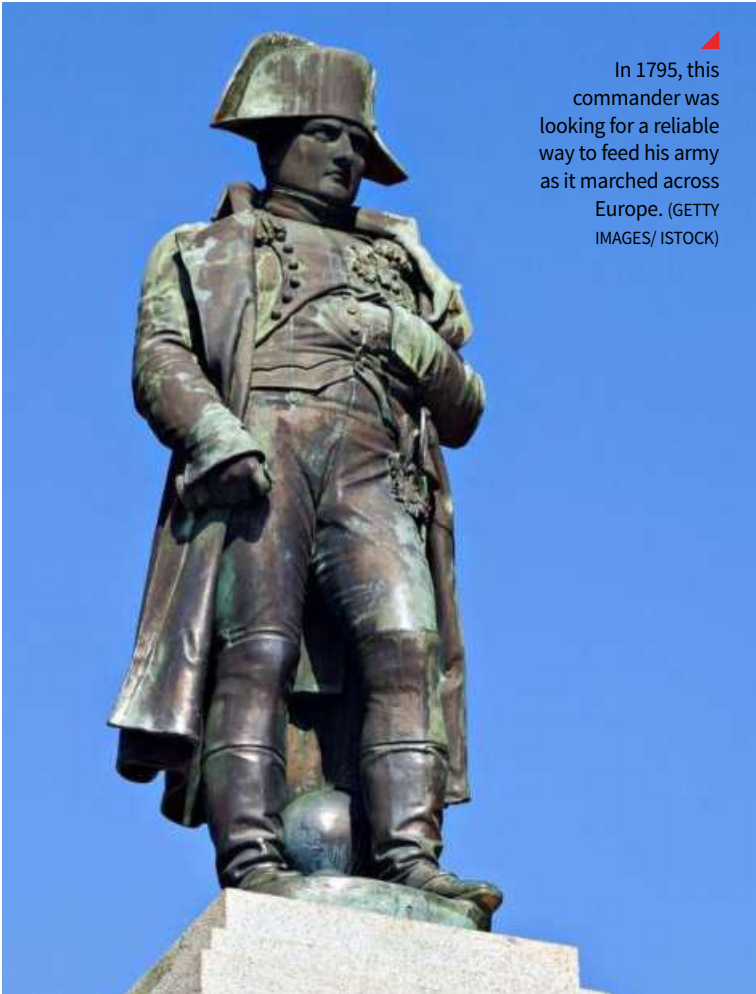
1 On July 12, 1859, William Goodale received a patent for his machine. It was not the first of its kind, but it was the most efficient, as it cut brown paper into pieces that could be folded into their final shape. What did it make that is now one of the world's most sustainable carrying solutions?

2 On July 12, 1940, Frederick McKinley Jones received a patent for a portable unit for trucks that revolutionised the long-distance transport of perishable goods such as food, blood and vaccines. What unit was this?

3 In 1795, this commander was looking for a reliable way to feed his army as it marched across Europe. He offered a cash prize (worth about U.S. \$35,000 today) for a solution. Nicolas Appert eventually won it for inventing food preservation through canning. Which commander is closely associated with this invention?

4 This is the name of a Swedish company that makes aseptic paper cartons for food and beverages. Its packaging has multiple protective layers, and its earliest cartons were four-sided triangles, giving the company its name. Which company, now synonymous with beverage cartons, is this?

5 This quintessential packaging material was invented by



In 1795, this commander was looking for a reliable way to feed his army as it marched across Europe. (GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK)

sealing two shower curtains together. The inventors first tried selling it as wallpaper and later as greenhouse insulation. Which material, also popular as a stress-buster, is this?

6 These uniquely designed packaging trays are increasingly being made from recycled paper and board. They

are geometrically designed to provide maximum protection from the sides, where an item is the most vulnerable. What packaging item, which usually holds multiples of six, is this?

7 These packaging fillers are designed to fill empty spaces in boxes and protect fragile items during shipping. Their distinctive

shape, inspired by a common legume, allows them to interlock under compression and reduce movement in transit. What are they called?

8 Corrugated cardboard is one of the world's most common packaging materials. It consists of a fluted sheet sandwiched between linerboards for strength. It was first patented in England in 1856 as a liner for which Victorian wardrobe item, helping keep it straight?

9 This company is renowned for its packaging, designed to reflect the sleek, minimalist aesthetic of the products inside. In the era of "unboxing" videos, its white boxes are often considered among the most satisfying to open. Which company is this?

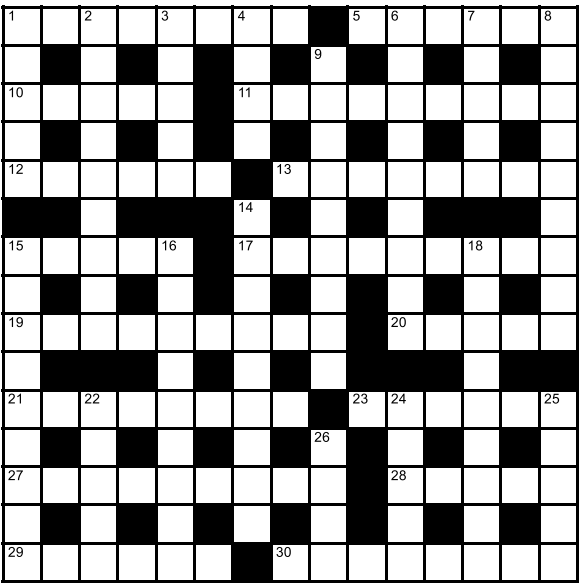
10 A sustainable packaging material is made from the naturally fallen sheaths of the areca palm. Water-resistant and mouldable into plates and bowls, it comes from the same tree that produces which nut, chewed across South and Southeast Asia for thousands of years?

A molecular biologist from Madurai, our quizmaster enjoys trivia and music, and is working on a rock ballad called 'Coffee is a Drink, Kaapi is an Emotion'. @bertyashley

- 1. Paper bag
- 2. Refrigerated truck unit
- 3. Napoleon Bonaparte
- 4. Tetra Pak
- 5. Bubble wrap
- 6. Egg carton
- 7. Packing peanuts
- 8. Top hats
- 9. Apple
- 10. Betel nut, aka sindoor

Answers

THE HINDU SUNDAY CROSSWORD NO. 64 (Set by Incognito)

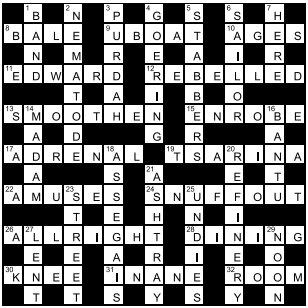


- Across**
1 Reverse vehicle after fire at English sports event (4,4)
5 Being short of money, repaired purdah (4,2)
10 Sign at end of terminus (5)
11 Thespian reportedly going after maid's role (9)
12 Irks a couple of Poles on yellow ship at for starters (6)
13 Having enthusiasm, madam catches flying owl to get beetle larva (8)
15 On return, massage mummy in Myanmar (5)
17 Fuss over sailors and soldiers on top of tank getting decoration (9)
19 Means of enlightenment on streets? (9)
20 Frigate leaving refrigerator at sea... That's a mistake... (5)
21 Homing pigeons, perhaps, cruise or fly around (8)
23 Finally, map book is with team leader (2,4)
27 Madly insane to kidnap writer in mountain range (9)
28 Bread maker from Talliparamba, Kerala (5)
29 Animals consuming some plantains and fruits (6)
30 Heard van destroyed porch (8)

- Down**
1 Old spelling of capital from misplaced mails (5)
2 Puzzle sister hides in company container (9)

- 3 Romeo is king at end of day... It's dangerous (5)
4 Prepare gun for shooting bird (4)
6 Immediately upon looking at a girl, knight gives up lot (2,1,6)
7 Do as before (5)
8 Gadget from Apple includes one crumpled can (9)
9 A place of refuge given by Peter is at hotel near river (4,5)
14 Suspended, including damaged trams, and hindered (9)
15 Ski mask produced by a lab rejected.. having cold and hot material! (9)
16 Gadget from Apple includes one crumpled can (9)
18 "Reserved" sign affixed to appendage (9)
22 Fully consume energy in American state (3,2)
24 To some extent, Rita blamed drum (5)
25 Something to carry for an old flame? (5)
26 Insular land lies in tatters (4)

SOLUTION NO. 63



Four goats in a rickety cart

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The morning arrived just like every other morning. The road to the office was crowded – buses exhaling smoke into the air, and tea shops breathing out the smell of cardamom, boiling milk and fried snacks. People moved quickly, checking their watches as if time itself was chasing them. I moved among them too, another quiet passenger carried forward by routine, heading toward another day that promised nothing unusual.

Then I saw a cart. It moved slowly along the side of the road, its wooden wheels trembling over uneven tar. Inside it stood four goats, tied close together. One of them tried licking the ear of another. One looked lazily at the sky. Another chewed calmly lost in the simple rhythm of being alive. There was something unbearably innocent about them – as though they believed the road ahead held nothing worse than distance. And that was what unsettled me, because I knew where they were being taken. The cart moved ahead gently, almost tenderly, making the horror inside it feel even more unbearable. The goats' eyes carried no fear. Their entire world existed inside that single passing morning.

For a brief moment, traffic vanished around me. The noise faded. I felt something collapse quietly inside my chest. I wanted to cry, not just for them, but for us too. We are also travellers asleep inside moving carts, dreaming as though we know where the journey ends. We laugh, make plans for next month, fall in love, and carefully prepare for festivals. We waste hours on petty arguments, collect smiling photographs like proof against mortality, and close our eyes each night with the soft illusion that tomorrow belongs to us. None of us really knows where the road bends. We live like those goats, breathing peacefully inside a fate we cannot read. And maybe that blindness is a form of mercy. Perhaps if every creature understood its fate completely, the world would become too heavy to carry.

As my car moved forward, my mind wandered into unseen corners of lives. Somewhere, a little girl might be braiding her doll's hair that same morning, laughing as if life were made only of birthdays, spinning skirts, and television songs. Elsewhere, another might be sitting under a dim bulb, studying with steady hope of becoming a doctor. How strange life is. The world slowly limits us and calls it destiny. I reached the office eventually. People were discussing deadlines. Someone laughed loudly near the elevator. Someone spoke of traffic like it was a minor inconvenience. Computer screens glowed. Phones rang. Everything continued with its usual precision. But somewhere inside me, four goats were still standing quietly in that cart beneath the morning sky. Still innocent. Still trusting. Still alive for a few more moments...



ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R. KUMAR

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The future of education, I recently discovered, arrived not in a government white paper or a Silicon Valley keynote, but in the bedroom of my 12-year-old nephew. He had been assigned an essay, a perfectly ordinary school task, designed to cultivate clarity, argument, and intellectual temperament. He opened his laptop, summoned a chatbot, and issued an instruction that was at once comic and chilling: “Write the essay, but make a few small mistakes so my teacher doesn’t realise it wasn’t written by me.”

There it was. No sense of plagiarism in the old-fashioned sense, but a performance management to get the right score. The machine was to think for him as well as simulate adolescent fallibility. It had to sprinkle in minor blotches, the academic equivalent of cosmetic freckles, so that authenticity might appear intact.

We might have dismissed this as youthful cunning were it not for the recent episode involving a platform brazenly named Einstein AI. Unlike the gentler educational “assistants” currently marketed by major technology companies, Einstein AI did not confine itself to offering suggestions or summarising lecture notes. Einstein AI promised to log into students’ virtual learning environments and complete their assignments “while they slept”. It would even submit the work from the student’s own account “just like you would”, having digested lectures and course material in advance. A perfect academic doppelgänger. No late nights. No panic. No existential wrestling with footnotes.

Predictably, outrage followed leading to the name vanishing from public view almost as quickly as it had appeared. But its brief existence exposed a trajectory that many prefer not to confront. If a chatbot can generate a competent essay in seconds, what remains of the educational process beyond editing and concealment?

The curious case of engineered errors

Adapting to an environment that prizes outcomes over growth of the person

My nephew, without knowing it, had grasped the logic perfectly. If the machine produces flawless prose, suspicion arises. Therefore, imperfection must be engineered. Interestingly, we have reached the point where human weakness must be algorithmically manufactured in order to preserve the illusion of human effort.

The defenders of these systems insist that they are merely tools. And of course, every intellectual age has had its tools. The printing press multiplied access to knowledge. The calculator relieved us of tedious arithmetic. The Internet collapsed distance. But tools traditionally extended human capacity and did not smother the human agent altogether.

A cancelled voyage

The image of the ship sailing across the globe collecting knowledge came to my mind. It was Francis Bacon who once imagined knowledge as a disciplined voyage, a collective enterprise in which inquiry, experiment, and observation advanced human understanding with ships venturing outward, gathering discoveries, returning enriched. Knowledge required movement, engagement, and daring. What would Bacon make of a system in which the voyage is cancelled and the cargo delivered by a drone?

I remember, early on in school, my teacher introduced us to Cardinal Newman’s *The Idea of a University*, where he argues that education is the cultivation of the intellect, the training of judgment through sustained engagement. The essay, in that tradition, is not merely a product to

be evaluated but a process where drafting, faltering, revising are not inconveniences but the very substance of learning. Remove the process, and you may still produce a text but not produce an educated mind. I learnt this when still in junior school where writing the essay was our daily task. Confronting the mute page with a pen in hand and no downloading or copy-pasting.

I realised my nephew’s strategy reveals the cultural shift beneath the technology. He is not rebelling against education; he is adapting to an environment in which outcomes are prized above inward growth. If the grade is what counts, and the machine can secure the grade, then so be it. A few inserted mistakes become camouflage, a proof not of stupidity but of strategy.

We should resist the temptation to treat this as harmless ingenuity. When systems are built that can replicate the visible markers of learning, institutions risk mistaking simulation for substance. The question raised by Einstein AI is not whether such platforms should exist but whether universities are prepared to confront what they imply. If assignments can be delegated entirely, assessment itself loses meaning.

There is something faintly comic about instructing a machine to “add mistakes”. Yet the humour carries an edge. We are teaching a generation that authenticity is a surface effect to be programmed. We are encouraging them to treat thinking as a service that can be subtly disguised.

The only unmistakably human trace left in the essay is the deliberately planted error.

FEEDBACK

Letters to the Magazine can be e-mailed separately to mag.letters@thehindu.co.in by Tuesday 3 p.m.

Cover story

Much of America's present strength has also been enriched by the contributions of immigrants who made the country their home. Combined with strong institutions and a culture of innovation, they have made the United States an enduring force in the world.

S. Raghavan

Is it possible under the current U.S. President to chase the American dream or is it a mirage or distant dream?

V. Padmanabhan

At this juncture, one must ponder whether it's worth spending lakhs to go live in the U.S. despite diminishing prospects. It would be better to find prosperous avenues in our motherland and lead a serene life here.

Ratna Naidu

Meena Kandasamy's point about caste being central to online misogyny, rather than borrowed Western frameworks, deserves wider attention. ('Sex, lies and the Indian manosphere'; July 5) Content moderation policies in India often overlook this local specificity. Platforms and researchers studying online abuse should build caste-sensitive frameworks instead of importing Western definitions wholesale.

S. Durga Arunkumar

The writer has aptly put forth many aspects of scrutiny over women's bodies and the proliferation of capitalism based entirely off women's insecurities about their bodies.

Neha Jha



MORE ON THE WEB
www.thehindu.com/opinion/openpage

Alchemy of gold

The stark reality is that the modern global economy still runs overwhelmingly on the yellow metal

Niharika Singh

The toy story

How the packaging builds anticipation in a child

Saandeep Kalavat

Forsaking values

For the mad race, people compromise on a peaceful life and health

Sajna Hameed

The loneliness of the elderly

They realise that whatever they have achieved in life is immaterial

Venkatraman N.S.

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Life has a way of presenting harsh truths, when we least expect it. The other day, I was dropped at a milk parlour, halfway home. I decided to stock on dairy before taking an autorickshaw. I fished out my purse and checked its contents.

Suddenly, an elderly woman perhaps in her seventies came and stood right in front of me. I quickly shoved my purse into the handbag. Before I could move, she held my hands. Her grip was firm. When I looked at her with alarm, she looked at me sternly and told me that no matter how angry one is, one must never wish death on anyone.

I understood every word of what she said in Kannada. I was flabbergasted. What on earth made her say that to me? There were customers at the shop. No one seemed to be bothered. Even before I could respond, she side-stepped me only to hold the hand of a young man

The irony of life

Most families, especially the women, dealing with a loved one's addiction go through despair and despondency



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

passing by. She repeated what she had just told me. He nodded his head in acceptance and she let go of him. She raised her vacant eyes and hands towards the skies and went on to cross the road.

I felt dazed. The shopkeeper offered a chair to me. Soon, all those at the shop

started talking about the woman. She was a widow. She had lost her children. She never begged. She washed vessels at the temple. She swept the school grounds in the evenings for supper. Sometimes she lost her mind.

Even as I was trying to piece together a story, the shopkeeper told me that the

woman lived in the vicinity. She had lost her husband and her two sons in a car accident a couple of years ago. All of them were drunk on that day. She had spent the best part of her life dealing with an alcoholic family which was incorrigible. No amount of affection or admonishment could turn them around.

Feeling guilty

Then the frustrated woman took to berating, cursing, and even wishing them dead. And on that fateful day when her sinister wish came true, she was flabbergasted. She felt guilty and responsible for the tragedy.

Her bereavement did not stop her from working. In fact, she was never caught slacking in her duties.

Yet, whenever she felt overwhelmed, she would slip into some kind of a trance. Then she would advise a few random people that they should not wish anyone dead.

I looked for her. She had disappeared. My heart felt heavy. I walked back home all the way. The sight of the bereaved woman stayed in my mind. I was reminded of

Coleridge's poem *The Rime of the Ancient Mariner*, who shared his experiences of guilt and repentance after having shot an albatross.

But this woman had tried her best to salvage the lives of her loved ones. She had donned the role of a virago in the hope that they would turn around. When her worst fears of losing them forever came true in the most ominous way, she blamed herself for the tragedy.

The more I thought about her state of mind, I realised that she was not alone in her grief. Most families that deal with some kind of addiction go through similar despair and despondency. Most often, the women in the family bear the brunt of it physically, emotionally, and economically. Occasionally, when some such catastrophe strikes, the vicious cycle of blame, guilt and grief sets in. The well-wishers of the malefactors are traumatised for the rest of their lives. They are haunted and victimised by the tragic consequences of the very ill they were fighting against!

Such is the irony of life!



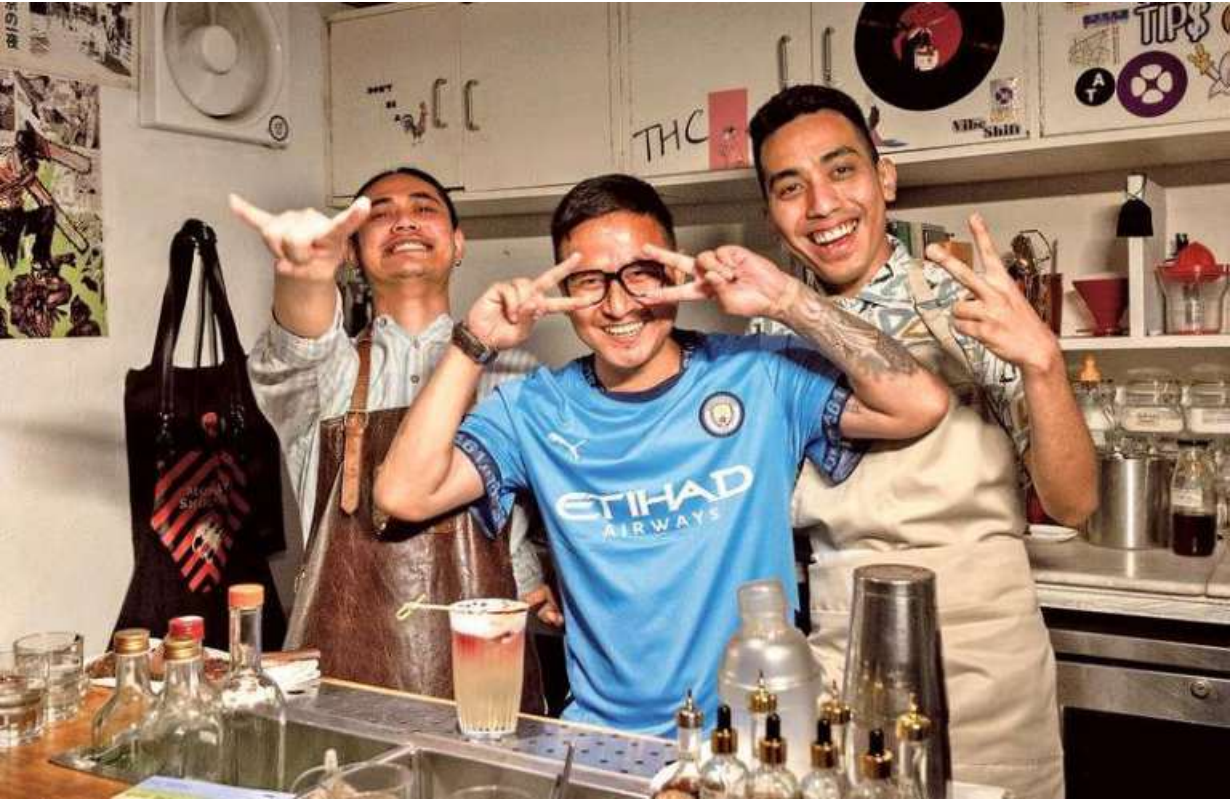
Joanna Lobo

Anjuna beach. A hammock over the sand. The setting sun. Waves crashing below. This is Pisco by the Beach, a sundowner spot known for its boho vibe and good seafood. Once night falls, a wooden door opens at the corner of the restaurant, leading into a private sitting room with a noticeable change in atmosphere and sound – not quite silent, but filled with the low cadence of conversation and music. This is After Dinner, a cocktail bar sharing the same view as Pisco, but offering a complete change of pace.

Welcome to the new experience in India's ever evolving bar scene: the nested bar. Small as their name suggests, and intentionally intimate, these sometimes one-room spaces are tucked away in lofts, basements, and back rooms in existing restaurants and bars.

Globally, the name for these bars is the very dry dual-concept spaces. But the idea is the same: sibling spaces under one roof that offer guests one-on-one access to the bartender and mixologists, personalised attention, and an exclusive cocktail and food menu. Think of it as a chef's table, but for the bar. "As bartenders, we also crave a room that's just about drinks," says Neil D'Souza, founder of Goa's Slow Tide. "It honestly comes from wanting to do two things in the same space without diluting either," he adds.

In the last year, India has embraced the concept. Delhi's Barbet & Pals has Cavity doing a nine-seat, nine-course cocktail tasting, and Olive in Mehrauli has the four-seater The Hidden Club.



EVERYONE'S LOVING BARS WITHIN BARS

These nested spaces are like a chef's table for cocktail aficionados — encouraging conversations, one-on-ones with mixologists, and the chance to nerd out over drinks

Mumbai's Slink & Bardot now houses Koliwada Cocktail Club (KCC) offering a six-course savoury cocktail tasting menu. Bengaluru's Una Hacienda has The Bunker Room, and the Leela Bengaluru's ZLB23 has The Theatre. In Goa, The Second House opened Bartender's Bunker, their experimental cocktail space turned lab, and coming soon is Bar O at Bar Outrigger, a four-seater space to explore techniques and ingredients.

In Mumbai, the 25-seater KCC is hidden from Slink & Bardot by a velvet curtain, and painted in deep blue with plush seating. "A great cocktail bar should create space for slower drinking, meaningful conversations, and a deeper appreciation of the craft behind every drink," explains partner-founder Vik Singh, for whom KCC fills a gap in the market. Similarly, Delhi's The Theatre was birthed from the realisation that they had room to create a more "immersive and narrative-led extension". The nested bar puts on "shows" – drinks served as a multi-course meal, with visual aids explaining them.

Facetime with the bartender

A nested bar isn't to be mistaken for a secret bar. The latter offers a 'hidden' experience where access can often be exclusionary (either through invitation or a hefty fee). Nested bars are open to all; the space merely allows for an unbridled creativity that the main bar cannot replicate. The menus here are heavy on technique and storytelling, and most serve a cocktail tasting menu.

Cavity offers a two-and-a-half hour, nine-course cocktail tasting menu. The focus is on India's GI ingredients: house-fermented Sunderban honey mead, Tamil Nadu's Tooyamalli Rice in a cocktail of the same name. KCC has a six-course liquid 'dinner', starting with an *amuse-bouche* and ending with dessert – namely, savoury cocktails such as Sushi and Tamales. The Bunker Room seats 8-10 people and does a four-course cocktail *omakase*.

"With these bars, you can get into the thinking and nerdiness around the drink, while also cutting away from the noise," says Somanna Muthanna, founder and CEO, The Soul Company. One of the most rewarding aspects, adds Singh of KCC, is that



conversations can evolve far beyond the drink. "As there are fewer seats and a slower pace, bartenders have the opportunity to spend more time with each guest. That creates a level of engagement that's difficult to achieve in a larger, busier environment," he says.

This 'facetime' is a big draw with customers. "In a bigger bar, you cannot get an in-depth perspective on the drinks," says Palki Hatangadi, a Bengaluru-based fashion retail



(Clockwise from far left) Bartender's Bunker in Goa; the bar team at The Hidden Club in Mehrauli, Delhi; Holding Hands cocktail at The Hidden Club; The Theatre in Bengaluru; the Morel at KCC Mumbai; Koliwada Cocktail Club; and The Stoned Pig in Goa. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



professional. "It adds to the cocktail drinking experience: you are improving what you know and how you understand the drinks."

'Smaller groups, better conversations'

Access to a nested bar is all about intention and, of course, money. The multi-course cocktail tastings start from approximately ₹2,000 to ₹4,000 per person and can go up to ₹8,000. To some customers, this is similar to what you would pay at a regular cocktail bar. To others, it is expensive but one they wouldn't mind indulging in because of the personalised attention and intimate experience.

"How people spend their night has changed. They want smaller groups, better conversations, and want to pay more attention to what they're drinking," says D'Souza of Slow Tide. "These spaces work

because they respect that shift." The customers are a mixed bag too, and span age groups – usually well-travelled people who have experienced cocktail bars around the world, and appreciate craft and storytelling. "At KCC, we've had everyone from industry professionals and cocktail enthusiasts to creatives, and entrepreneurs," says Singh. "What they tend to have in common is a willingness to engage, to ask questions." He recalls the occasional guest who spends 20 minutes discussing a single ingredient, or trying to understand how a familiar flavour has been transformed.

As Muthanna sums it up: "These bars make it possible to geek out over cocktails."

The writer is a freelance journalist and editor from Goa.



Mauritius and the conservation concierge

How top resorts such as Four Seasons are investing in beehives and reef restoration to protect the fragile systems that underpin the island's beauty

Karen Anand

In a small island in the Indian Ocean with a population of just 1.26 million, tourism is not simply an industry, it is the economic backbone. Which is why what is happening in Mauritius today is both interesting and important: conservation has moved from the margins to the mainstream. Luxury hotels are leading the shift. Almost all the top-tier resorts are deeply invested in protecting the ecosystems that sustain them – through scientific research, full-time marine biologists,

structured education programmes, and long-term ecological restoration.

"Sustainability has to be a core pillar," says Anand Shekhawat, a keen watcher of conservation efforts worldwide, former global head of sustainability for Aman Resorts and founder of Sariska Lodge in Rajasthan. "The subject is vast, making it important for organisations to engage with sustainability managers who work on areas ranging from water, air, soil, flora and fauna, to communities and education."

Let's begin by mapping the sustainability infrastructure in Mauritius. In the south, Heritage

Resort in Bel Ombre employs full-time marine biologists who work on the regeneration of seagrass and coral ecosystems. They have also been running a Marine Education Centre in partnership with Reef Conservation for the last two years helping introduce guests to lagoon biodiversity, coral reefs, seagrass beds and coastal forests – fragile systems that underpin Mauritius's postcard beauty.

On the west coast, Sugar Beach in Flic-en-Flac has its own resident scientist, embedding environmental stewardship into daily resort life. Further north, Attitude hotel has taken an

(Clockwise from left) Mangroves at the Four Seasons; a bee keeper; and Rick Bonnier. (SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT)



immersive approach through its Marine Discovery Centre where conservation is participatory: citizen science programmes led by marine biologists, organised beach clean-ups, guest participation in

updating marine databases.

To study how this movement has matured over time, Four Seasons Mauritius' coral restoration project that began in 2015 is a good example. As is the preservation of seagrass meadows within the resort's lagoon. In 2021, the resort on the east coast expanded into seahorse regeneration initiatives, and more recently into reef restoration and beehive protection across its sprawling 64-acre property. "We aim to restore 10,000 sq. m of coral reef," shares conservationist Rick Bonnier, the resort's Ocean Environment Manager. "We have planted around 1,000 coral fragments, and this has already improved biodiversity and the number of fish in the area. For the bee project [introduced last May], we started with eight hives and around 250,000 bees. Now there are around 500,000. We are collecting data to study its impact." Edited excerpts from a conversation with Bonnier:

Question: Why a beehive project?
Answer: We are surrounded by

The green plan

Since the Sustainable Island Mauritius Project was launched in 2008, tourism operators have implemented wide-ranging eco-friendly measures. These include banning single-use plastics, wastewater recycling, food waste reduction, mangrove rehabilitation, sea turtle protection projects, and development of eco-friendly accommodation. Mauritius is now working towards achieving a Green Destinations label by 2030.

mangroves, which are highly dynamic ecological systems, and bees are essential pollinators, including for mangrove flowers. Our aim is to create a safe space for bees – whose populations worldwide are declining due to habitat destruction, pesticide use and pollution. They increase pollination around the mangroves, and strengthen the surrounding ecosystem.

Q: What do you hope to achieve in the long term?

A: The first goal is increased biodiversity. A single honeybee can visit anywhere from 50 to 1,000 flowers in one trip, and effective pollination increases not just yield, but also the quality of fruits and plants. It also helps protect crops against pests, creating a stronger ecosystem. The second goal is producing high-quality, distinctive honey.

Q: What are the big projects on the island?

A: Mauritius is seeing a growing number of serious environmental initiatives. The Odysseo Foundation is pioneering seagrass farming and we are collaborating with them for phase 2 by providing a stretch of the resort's seafront. There is also coral farming led by Secore, a non-profit, where coral eggs are collected during spawning, grown in laboratories, and reintroduced into the sea. Sea cucumber farming projects are also underway, helping to restore balance to reef ecosystems.

The writer, consultant, and entrepreneur's latest venture is bespoke small group tours, which she curates and accompanies.